

WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-03-16 to 2026-03-22

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

COMAP Journal Bot pulled a large candidate pool this cycle and the curated set ends up leaning in three directions: computational approaches to political text and persuasion, digital campaign and platform effects, and broader questions about governance, inequality, and democratic participation. The strongest pieces for immediate opening are the AJPS paper on using large language models for political texts, the Science Advances paper on biased AI writing assistants, and a late Communication Research paper showing how radical right-wing political deepfakes can delegitimize targeted political actors.

Beyond those headliners, this week's packet has a useful mix of election behavior, ranked-choice voting, survey-response measurement, autocratic participation, coalition and protest-voting methods, and a few carefully selected general-science papers on governance over deep time, cross-national mortality inequality, conservation policy evaluation, cooperation on networks, and worker mobility. The full collected set below is much larger than the attached PDF because the broad-science journals were filtered aggressively for COMAP relevance.

- AI and computational social science are unusually prominent this week, especially around LLM-assisted writing and political text analysis.
- The communication set is strongest on electoral interfaces, stereotype effects, and synthetic-media harms.
- Late additions are substantial and worth checking rather than treating as leftovers; several core political science papers entered through catch-up and late-discovery paths.

HIGHLIGHTS

Using large language models to analyze political texts through natural language understanding

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-03-19

Why it matters · A strong methods piece for computational political text analysis: it treats LLMs as language-understanding tools rather than black-box summarizers, which is directly useful for COMAP-style measurement work.

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From Buttons to Bots: Exploring the Impact of Enhanced Features in Voting Advice Applications on Desktops and Smartphones

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-03-19

Why it matters · Worth opening for the platform-design angle: it links interface features and device context to how people process electoral guidance, with clear implications for digital political communication.

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The distribution of power and inclusiveness across deep time

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-03-20

Why it matters · This is the strongest broad-science keep of the week for governance research, offering a comparative framework for locating polities on a collective-versus-autocratic axis.

[Open article →](#)

Biased AI writing assistants shift users' attitudes on societal issues

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-03-13

Why it matters · Highly relevant to AI-mediated persuasion: the paper shows attitude movement from biased autocomplete suggestions even when users do not notice the slant.

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Exiting Russia

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-03-11

Why it matters · A timely APSR contribution on state-business relations under authoritarian pressure, with obvious relevance for sanctions, exit behavior, and political economy.

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Radical Right-Wing Political Deepfakes Can Successfully Delegitimize Targeted Political Actors: Evidence From Three-wave Experiments in the US and The Netherlands

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-03-04

Why it matters · One of the clearest multimodal political communication papers in the packet, with direct evidence on how deepfakes can damage democratic legitimacy.

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Perversity, futility, complicity: Should democrats participate in autocratic elections?

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-02-25

Why it matters · Especially aligned with COMAP interests in authoritarian politics because it tackles a recurring strategic dilemma inside manipulated electoral systems.

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Trapped in declining occupations: Barriers to worker mobility in a changing economy

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-03-06

Why it matters · This late addition broadens the digest beyond media and institutions with a careful account of how structural change constrains upward mobility in the labor market.

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COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES 139	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES 72	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES 21
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES 46	CURATED DIGEST BELOW 8 new, 5 catch-up, 20 late additions	NOTE The full collected set above is before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Science Advances

The distribution of power and inclusiveness across deep time

2026-03-20 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEC1426

Gary M. Feinman; David Stasavage; David M. Carballo; Sarah B. Barber; Adam Green; Jacob Holland-Lulewicz; Dan Lawrence; Jessica Munson; Linda M. Nicholas; Francesca Fulminante; Sarah Klassen; Keith W. Kintigh; John Douglass

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Abstract. This study presents a global, deep-time comparative analysis of governance, questioning entrenched viewpoints about the origins and evolution of democratic institutions. Drawing on archaeological and textual data from 40 case observations across 31 polities, we develop a quantitative framework to assess governance along a collective-autocratic axis, defined by two key dimensions: concentration of power and citizen inclusiveness. Using bridging arguments and robust proxies, we construct an autocracy index to assess where cases fall on this axis and examine them in relation to population size, hierarchical complexity, geographic region, modes of fiscal financing, bureaucratic structure, ritual practices, and socioeconomic inequality. Neither polity population nor geographic region tightly correlates with the collective-autocratic axis of governance, challenging extant neoevolutionary models. Instead, the strongest associations for autocratic governance are with external financing, patrimonial bureaucracy, spectacular ritual, and high inequality. The study underscores the diversity and persistence of collective governance, offering a scalable methodology for future comparative research and reframing historical narratives.

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American Journal of Political Science

Rulers on the road: Itinerant rule in the Holy Roman Empire, AD 919-1519

2026-03-19 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70047

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Abstract. Abstract Itinerant rule, rule exercised through traveling, was a common yet insufficiently researched, premodern form of governance. Studying the determinants of ruler itineraries in the Holy Roman Empire, AD 919-1519, we argue that rulers' visits targeted "marginal" elites. Powerful rulers could count on family members and thus targeted unrelated local elites. Weak emperors had to monitor their less loyal relatives and left unrelated nobles unvisited. We reconstruct emperors' itineraries from 72,665 dated and geolocated documents and measure territorial control by their relatives. Exploiting the weakening of imperial power through the Great Interregnum (1250-1273), we find that strong, pre1250 emperors frequented areas controlled by their relatives relatively less. In contrast, family control increased visits post1273. Causal identification rests on the discontinuous reduction of emperors' power through the Great Interregnum and differences in family relations between subsequent emperors. The results show strategic itinerant rule as an important but understudied form of governance.

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Using large language models to analyze political texts through natural language understanding

2026-03-19 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70050

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Abstract. Abstract Large language models (LLMs) offer scalable alternatives to human experts when analyzing political texts for meaning , using natural language understanding (NLU). Qualitative NLU methods relying on human experts are severely limited by cost and scalability. Statistical textasdata methods are scalable but rely on strong and often unrealistic assumptions. We propose a systematic, scalable, and replicable method that can extend existing qualitative and quantitative approaches by using LLMs to interpret texts meaningfully rather than as mere data. Our ensemble means of LLMgenerated estimates of party positions on six key issue dimensions correlate highly with equivalent mean ratings by country specialists. When applied to coalition policy declarations, LLM estimates align more closely with standard models of government formation than handcoded estimates. We conclude with a discussion of the profound implications of modern LLMs for political text analysis.

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You and whose economy? Groupbased retrospection in economic voting

2026-03-19 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70055

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Abstract. Abstract When managing the economy, governments make decisions that influence not only overall growth but also its distribution. How do voters judge incumbents for this? I revisit the idea of groupbased retrospective voting and argue that voters assess the economic performance of their social ingroups relative to the national economy. By sanctioning the incumbent for ingroup performance, voters can incentivize policymaking that better aligns with their interests. I test the theory, first, by estimating the relationship between ingroup performance and incumbent support in panel data. This relationship is comparable in magnitude to sociotropic voting. I further conduct three experiments in Denmark and the United States, randomizing information about the performance of groups defined by geography, age, education, ethnicity, and class. The findings suggest there are limits to sociotropic voting, as voters want their groups to follow or beat the national trend. This has important implications for electoral accountability and party competition.

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Communication Research

From Buttons to Bots: Exploring the Impact of Enhanced Features in Voting Advice Applications on Desktops and Smartphones

2026-03-19 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261425713

Christine Liebrecht; Naomi Kamoen; Rieke van Lieshout

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Abstract. Voters using Voting Advice Applications (VAAs) often struggle with comprehension, leading to satisficing behavior. Conversational Agent VAAs (CAVAAs) aim to improve understanding by allowing users to ask a chatbot comprehension questions. While early research shows positive effects, studies have only compared CAVAAs to basic VAAs, not to enhanced VAAs (VAA+s) with clickable information buttons. Current study compares four versions: a basic VAA, a VAA+, a CAVAA, and a CAVAA+, tested on desktop (Study 1) and smartphone (Study 2). Results show that all three information-rich versions reduce non-directional answers and positively impact political and tool evaluation measures, suggesting that added information, regardless of format, improves response quality and user experience. Interestingly, users request more information in the enhanced web-based VAA+ than via the chatbot. We discuss these and other findings in the paper.

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Differential Effects of Counter-Stereotypical Portrayals of Warmth Across Racial Groups: Behavioral and Experimental Evidence

2026-03-18 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261430969

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Abstract. This research examines how counter-stereotypical portrayals influence prosocial behavior across racial groups within the context of medical crowdfunding. Drawing on the stereotype content model and expectancy violation theory, we investigate how messages that contradict stereotypes of racial groups perceived as having low warmth violate expectations about these groups and influence campaign donations. Across two studies—an analysis of over 17,000 crowdfunding campaigns (Studies 1a-c) and an online experiment (N = 688; Study 2)—counter-stereotypical portrayals of warmth were associated with higher donations for Asian and White beneficiaries but with lower donations for Black beneficiaries. Expectancy violations mediated these effects, with Black beneficiaries experiencing smaller positive expectancy shifts than other groups. The findings highlight the differential effects of warm-based portrayals across racial groups when used to challenge stereotypes. The study advances theoretical frameworks on stereotypes and expectancy violations while offering practical guidance for more effective and equitable messaging strategies.

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Nature Communications

Behavioral shifts mask the success of legislation and outreach for endangered species recovery

2026-03-18 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-69617-4

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Abstract. Abstract A fundamental challenge in conservation is assessing the efficacy of recovery actions to optimize endangered species management. Considerable recent attention has focused on effective measures to counter the endangerment of avian scavengers, which have declined worldwide, primarily due to poisoning. One iconic example is efforts to recover the critically endangered California condor (*Gymnogyps californianus*), whose leading cause of death is poisoning from ingesting lead-based ammunition in carcasses. Despite enormous resources expended in California, USA, including implementation of public outreach campaigns and two legislative bans on lead ammunition, lead-related mortality of condors has increased. Here we show that two types of behavioral shifts explain the observed increases in condor lead exposure: wilder foraging and ranging by condors and increased shooting of wild pigs (*Sus scrofa*) by humans. After accounting for these trends, we show that both lead ammunition bans and public outreach efforts have significantly reduced condor blood lead levels in California, lowering mortality. Our analyses uncover a dynamic in which changing ecological conditions mask the true efficacy of legislation and outreach. Given rapid global change, such dynamics are likely operating in many settings, underscoring the importance of comprehensive evaluations of recovery actions, which can be obscured by shifting behaviors and threats.

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Decomposition of cross-country socioeconomic inequality in mortality by 288 causes of death and 84 risk factors from 1990 to 2021

2026-03-18 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-70877-3

Dong Peng; Rongbin Xu; Simon Hales; Lidia Morawska; Gongbo Chen; Zhengyu Yang; Yiwen Zhang; Michael J. Abramson; Shanshan Li; Yuming Guo

Abstract. Global cross-country socioeconomic inequalities in all-cause age-standardized mortality (SIAM) have persisted over decades, but major contributing causes and risk factors remain unclear. Here, we quantified contributions of 288 causes and 84 risk factors to SIAM using the Global Burden of Disease Study 2021 (GBD 2021). From 1990 to 2021, communicable, maternal, neonatal, and nutritional diseases' contribution fell from 81.2% to 56.6%, while non-communicable diseases' contribution from 13.2% to 27.8%. The top five causes of death contributing to SIAM in 2021 were COVID-19 (17.9%), stroke (9.4%), tuberculosis (7.3%), lower respiratory infections (7.0%), and diarrheal diseases (5.5%). The top five risk factors contributing to SIAM in 2021 were household air pollution from solid fuels (17.2%), high systolic blood pressure (9.9%), unsafe sex (4.6%), high fasting plasma glucose (4.4%), and unsafe water sources (4.2%). Overall, this study provides policymakers with data to promote global health equity by targeting key causes and risk factors contributing to cross-country mortality inequality.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

Science Advances

Biased AI writing assistants shift users' attitudes on societal issues

2026-03-13 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.ADW5578

Sterling Williams-Ceci; Maurice Jakesch; Advait Bhat; Kowe Kadoma; Lior Zalmanson; Mor Naaman

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Abstract. Artificial intelligence (AI) writing assistants powered by large language models (LLMs) are increasingly used to make autocomplete suggestions to people as they write text. Can these AI writing assistants affect people's attitudes in this process? In two large-scale preregistered experiments (N = 2582), we exposed participants writing about important societal issues to an AI writing assistant that provided biased autocomplete suggestions. When using the AI assistant, the attitudes participants expressed in a posttask survey converged toward the AI's position. However, a majority of participants were unaware of the AI suggestions' bias and their influence. Further, the influence of the AI writing assistant was stronger than the influence of similar suggestions presented as static text, showing that the influence is not fully explained by these suggestions, increasing accessibility of the biased information. Last, warning participants about assistants' bias before or after exposure does not mitigate the attitude-shift effect.

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Controlling noisy herds: Temporal network restructuring improves control of indecisive collectives

2026-03-13 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.ADX6791

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Abstract. Controlling stochastic temporal networks remains an open challenge in control theory. While predictable temporal networks with known future dynamics enhance controllability, real-world networks often exhibit stochasticity and unpredictability, making control harder. Here, we investigate control mechanisms for stochastic temporal networks by analyzing how biological controllers, such as shepherd dogs, manage panicked flocks of sheep. We study a century-old shepherding competition, the sheepdog trials, where small groups of sheep unpredictably switch between fleeing and following behaviors, effectively forming stochastic temporal networks. Unlike large, cohesive flocks, these small, indecisive flocks are difficult to control, yet skilled dog-handler teams excel at both herding and splitting them (shedding) on demand. Using a stochastic choice model to describe the sheep's behavioral shifts, we show that trained dogs exploit indecisiveness, typically seen as an obstacle, as a control tool, enabling both herding and splitting of noisy groups of sheep. Building on these insights, we develop the Indecisive Swarm Algorithm (ISA) for artificial agents and benchmark its performance against standard approaches, including the Averaging-Based Swarm Algorithm (ASA) and the Leader-Follower Swarm Algorithm (LFSA). ISA minimizes control energy in trajectory-following tasks and outperforms alternatives under noisy conditions. Framed within a stochastic temporal network perspective, we show that synchronizing network restructuring with state updates ($T = 1$) minimizes control energy for trajectory following tasks even without knowledge of future topology. These findings establish a framework for managing stochastic temporal networks with applications in noisy, indecisive animal collectives, swarm robotics, and opinion dynamics.

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American Journal of Political Science

Encouraging crossover voting in the 2024 presidential primary

2026-03-11 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70052

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Abstract. Will voters participate in the primary of a party they oppose to prevent the nomination of a candidate they fear? Partnering with a political action committee, we conduct a first-of-its-kind, large, preregistered field experiment ($N = 83,902$) in the leadup to the 2024 Republican presidential primary in New Hampshire. A specialized get-out-the-vote intervention increases turnout in the Republican primary among undeclared voters who are modeled as likely to vote for Democratic candidates in the general election. Our treatment increased Republican primary turnout in this sample by 1.6 percentage points while reducing turnout in the Democratic Primary by .5 percentage points. Supplementing our experiment with surveys before and after the primary, we estimate that each vote cast by Democratic-leaning voters in the Republican primary had between a 78% and 95% probability of supporting the relatively moderate Republican primary candidate. We argue that voters are capable of sophisticated, risk-mitigating behavior in primaries.

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American Political Science Review

Exiting Russia

2026-03-11 · DOI 10.1017/S000305542610152X

RACHEL L. WELLHAUSEN; BOLIANG ZHU

Pennsylvania State University; University of Texas at Austin

Abstract. As of February 24, 2022, over forty thousand foreign-invested firms operated in Russia, a host state that initiated an interstate war—an exceptional shock in the modern era of economic globalization. Using company registration data, we document that after 18 months of war, 33.3% of foreign-invested firms had changed ownership or become inactive. We conceptualize exit as a politicized transaction in which sellers and buyers face external pressures and bargain over terms. Concerning pressures to sell, those in consumer-oriented industries were more likely to exit. On bargaining, we find Russian state interests consequential: foreign-invested firms already under Russian managerial control were more likely to exit, whereas those in Russian strategic industries were not. Despite extraordinary economic sanctions to isolate Russia, and surging social backlash against doing business in Russia, results imply that multinationals are at best unstable tools of economic statecraft, even in the midst of war.

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Political Analysis

Inference at the Data's Edge: Gaussian Processes for Estimation and Inference in the Face of Extrapolation Uncertainty

2026-03-10 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10032

Soonhong Cho; Doeun Kim; Chad Hazlett

UCLA

Abstract. Abstract Many inferential tasks involve fitting models to observed data and predicting outcomes at new covariate values, requiring interpolation or extrapolation. Conventional methods select a single best-fitting model, discarding fits that were similarly plausible in-sample but would yield sharply different predictions out-of-sample. Gaussian processes (GPs) offer a principled alternative. Rather than committing to one conditional expectation function, GPs deliver a posterior distribution over outcomes at any covariate value. This posterior effectively retains the range of models consistent with the data, widening uncertainty intervals where extrapolation magnifies divergence. In this way, the GP's uncertainty estimates reflect the implications of extrapolation on our predictions, helping to tame the "dangers of extreme counterfactuals" (King and Zeng, 2006). The approach requires (i) specifying a covariance function linking outcome similarity to covariate similarity and (ii) assuming Gaussian noise around the conditional expectation. We provide an accessible introduction to GPs with emphasis on this property, along with a simple, automated procedure for hyperparameter selection implemented in the R package gpss. We illustrate the value of GPs for capturing counterfactual uncertainty in three settings: (i) treatment effect estimation with poor overlap, (ii) interrupted time series requiring extrapolation beyond pre-intervention data, and (iii) regression discontinuity designs where estimates hinge on boundary behavior.

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Late Additions

American Journal of Political Science

Longrun confidence: Estimating uncertainty when using longrun multipliers

2026-03-07 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70053

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Abstract. Abstract Researchers are often interested in the longrun relationship (LRR) between variables where the dependent variable has dynamic properties. Though determining the longrun multiplier (LRM) for an independent variable is straightforward, correctly estimating the significance of the LRM is often difficult, especially when time series are short and tests for series' stationarity are uncertain. We propose a Bayesian framework for estimating the LRM by using a bounded prior on the lagged dependent variable to constrain estimates for dynamic processes to the plausible range of values arising from either stationary or integrated series, and then taking draws of the posterior distribution to summarize the credible region. Doing so provides direct estimates of the LRM and its uncertainty, even for short time series. We highlight the advantages of this approach via Monte Carlo experiments and replicate several studies to show that our method clarifies LRRs that were inconclusive using existing techniques.

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Politics transformed? Electoral competition under ranked choice voting

2026-03-05 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70040

Peter Buisseret; Carlo Prato

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Abstract. Abstract We compare multicandidate elections under plurality rule versus ranked choice voting (RCV). We examine a widely held presumption that RCV more effectively incentivizes candidates to pursue broad campaigns that can appeal to all voters, rather than targeting a narrow segment of the electorate. That presumption is correct when preference transfers are competitive, that is, when multiple candidates have a reasonable chance of securing voters' secondchoice support. However, when transfers are uncompetitive due to partisan, ethnic, or cultural alignments, that presumption is reversed: RCV can strengthen candidates' incentives to pursue targeted campaigns.

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The declarations of independents: Openended survey responses and the nature of nonidentification

2026-03-05 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70048

Maxwell B. Allamong; Benjamin Beutel; Jongwoo Jeong; Paul M. Kellstedt

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Abstract. Abstract While many Americans identify as politically "independent," conventional wisdom suggests most are covert partisans, especially "leaners." However, we argue that independents exhibit distinct attitudes toward political parties. Analyzing American National Election Studies openended responses from 1984 to 2020, we employ structural topic models and support vector machines to explore differences in how independents and partisans express "dislikes" about the major parties. Our results show that leaning independents differ significantly from selfidentified partisans in their language and align more closely with pure independents. Furthermore, we find that independents are more likely than partisans to mention issues related to "politics"-such as political cynicism, concern about special interests, or distaste for partisan conflict-when discussing their "dislikes." These findings suggest that independents have meaningful distinctions from partisans beyond voting behavior, cautioning against overlooking the nuances between these groups.

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Mitigating policy uncertainty: What financial markets reveal about firmlevel lobbying

2026-03-04 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70043

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Abstract. Abstract Elections can lead to substantial policy changes and, thus, are a significant source of risk. Firms can respond to such policy uncertainty by lobbying, but it is hard to quantify whether they do so and, if so, how much lobbying benefits them. We construct a new dataset and leverage investors' expectations of variability in stock returns in the aftermath of the 2020 US presidential election to generate a new firmlevel measure of exposure to policy uncertainty. We show that lobbying reduces policy uncertainty, and that this result holds even after controlling for selection into lobbying and sectoral heterogeneity. We then develop and quantify a model of heterogeneous firms with endogenous lobbying. We find that affecting policy through lobbying is costly and the returns from it are highly skewed and rapidly diminishing. Thus, while lobbying expenditures reduce the impact of policy risk, few firms anticipate sufficient gains to invest in it.

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The economic foundations of powersharing: Evidence from Africa

2026-03-04 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70041

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Abstract. Abstract How-and with whom-do rulers share power? Existing research focuses on the strategic logic of powersharing. In this paper, we analyze its economic foundations. Powersharing is modeled as a subnational fiscal contract, in which rulers allocate political representation based on constituencies' revenue potential. Empirically, we combine historical geospatial data on different types of primary commodity production-mineral point resources and diffuse smallholder cash crop agriculture-with the ethnic affiliation of cabinet ministers across 15 African countries. We find that cash crop groups are overrepresented in postindependence cabinets, while mining or food crop production does not translate into higher shares of power. Consistent with a revenue bargaining framework, we find that rulers traded political representation and targeted public services for indirect taxation of cash crops. Overall, this suggests powersharing serves not only as a means to distribute resources and coopt potential challengers but also to expand the pie and the rents at the ruler's disposal.

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Latinos mobilizing beyond threats: The role of fear and hope in issue activism

2026-02-25 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70037

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Abstract. Abstract Interest groups intent on spurring political participation often highlight potential threats to galvanize audiences into action. However, while loss aversion is typically seen as a strong motivator, it is important not to neglect the motivational effect of hope and rewardseeking behavior as people navigate their political landscape. By drawing on a renewed focus on the simultaneous role of positive and negative emotions when processing risk appraisals, this paper reassesses the most effective ways to frame threat messages surrounding immigration activism. I test the major claims of this model with two original online survey experiments of Latino adults in the United States (n = 1,001; n = 1,266), including a vignette and emotioninduction design. The results demonstrate that a mobilizing message combining elements of both threat (loss) and opportunity (gain)-primed by negative and positive emotions-is a significant catalyst of various forms of collective action, including informal and formal forms of political participation.

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Perversity, futility, complicity: Should democrats participate in autocratic elections?

2026-02-25 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70049

Zoltan Miklosi

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Abstract. Abstract Electoral authoritarianism is receiving increasing attention from political scientists, yet it has been mostly ignored by political philosophers. This paper aims to fill some of this gap by considering whether it is morally permissible for democrats to participate in autocratic elections as candidates or voters. Autocratic elections allow meaningful multiparty competition but are systematically unfair and partly unfree, and therefore, arguably, normatively illegitimate. The paper considers three objections to participation in autocratic elections. These objections hold, respectively, that participation has bad consequences for democratization, that it is normatively futile, and that it is morally wrong in itself. The paper argues that the objections are not decisive, and that participation is usually morally permissible and even preferable over alternative forms of challenge. However, the objections establish that the normative superiority of electoral challenge over the alternatives is only a matter of degree, and that participants often dirty their hands.

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American Political Science Review

Reconfiguring the Global Color Line: The Paradoxical Discourse of Race in Zou Rong's *Revolutionary Army*

2026-03-06 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101464

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University of Florida

Abstract. This article examines the racial discourse of Zou Rong, a 20th-century Chinese radical intellectual, and the puzzling rendering of transnational racial politics at work in his pamphlet *The Revolutionary Army*. In this text, Zou employs the imported concept of race to refashion Han Chinese identity within a politically motivated global racial taxonomy. He then problematizes the "double enslavement" of the Han race at the trans-imperial nexus of domestic Manchu domination and global white supremacy. Finally, he urges a multifront revolution in China by discursively vindicating Han Chinese racial uplift within a newly reconfigured system of racial hierarchy. In reconstructing the formation and broader political stakes of Zou's racial discourse, this article centers the deeply contingent and paradoxical alignment of racism and imperialism and the nuanced power relations between peoples of color. It also exemplifies a transnational approach to comparative political theory that focuses on the circulation and negotiation of ideas.

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Initiate and Elevate! How Political Parties Can Set an Agenda

2026-03-03 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101506

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Abstract. The study of political agenda setting is a cornerstone in political science. Within this literature, political parties are implicitly portrayed as being capable of proactively initiating discussions. However, this fundamental notion of party agency deserves further theoretical and empirical attention. In response, this article crafts a new model (the Issue Initiation Model) that opens the window into parties' efforts to set an agenda and traces how they initiate and elevate their agenda. The model is tested on an original dataset covering more than 5.5-million tweets by political parties and MPs, coupled with over 750,000 news articles and 419,000 parliamentary questions in the United Kingdom and Denmark from 2015 to 2022. Results show how parties and their MPs can proactively redirect the attention of other actors through strategic planning and orchestrated actions. By theorizing and empirically testing the implicit notion that parties can proactively initiate discussions, this article has important implications for political agenda setting.

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Partisan Expressive Responding: Lessons from Two Decades of Research

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Abstract. Research on partisan expressive responding suggests that the beliefs people express in surveys are more partisan than their underlying perceptions. This article examines the scope and importance of expressive responding through a meta-reanalysis of 44 studies from 25 articles. On average, treatments designed to reduce expressive responding shrink measured partisan bias by about 25%. Across the 242 survey questions in the data, treatments increase the correlation between the average Democrat's and Republican's beliefs from 0.81 to 0.86. Contrary to expectations derived from the two leading theories of expressive responding, misreporting ("cheerleading") and congenial inference, there is no evidence that expressive responding increases in partisan identity strength or educational attainment. As research on expressive responding enters its third decade, greater emphasis on design-based tests of mechanisms may help build a firmer understanding of the nature and substantive importance of expressive responding—namely, whether the forces that produce expressive responding in surveys also shape real-world political judgments.

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Scrutiny and Recall: Rousseau on Controlling the Executive

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Abstract. In recent decades, political theorists have drawn on historical thinkers to explore how political elites can be held accountable. Rousseau, however, is often dismissed as reducing accountability to elections and participation to occasional ratification referenda. This article challenges that view. While Rousseau expected an elective aristocracy to execute laws ratified by the people, he also identified two mechanisms-scrutiny and recall-through which citizens could control these representatives. After reconstructing Rousseau's account, I consider how these mechanisms could be adapted to contemporary democracies. Focused on executive accountability, the model is particularly suited to presidential systems with directly elected presidents. It combines a national jury-a citizens' assembly chosen by lot and tasked with examining presidential actions-with the possibility of a recall referendum. By uniting deliberative scrutiny with the power to remove the head of state, this approach offers an underexplored complement to recent anti-oligarchic institutional innovations based on sortition.

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The Cornered Mouse: Sanctioned Elites and Authoritarian Realignment in the Japanese Legislature, 1936-1942

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Abstract. This study examines how economic elites respond to the erosion of democratic checks and balances, focusing on the Japanese legislature from 1936 to 1942. Using an original dataset of Diet members' biographies and board memberships, it analyzes the Imperial Japanese Army's consolidation of power and shifts in parliamentary voting patterns amid the suppression of dissent. Employing difference-in-differences and event-study designs, this study evaluates the effects of two key shocks: economic sanctions and wartime procurement. Legislators tied to sanction-hit sectors-such as textiles and petrochemicals, the weakest performers in the stock market-shifted toward authoritarian alignment. Biographical and legislative records suggest this shift was facilitated by regime-backed campaign finance. In contrast, legislators from procurement-dependent sectors, such as automobiles, maintained stable voting behavior. The findings complicate the conventional view that sanctions prompt elites to advocate international policy change. Instead, they show that sanctions can drive vulnerable actors to submit domestically, thereby accelerating authoritarian consolidation.

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When the Church Votes Left: How Progressive Bishops Supported the Workers' Party in Brazil

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Abstract. Social scientists routinely characterize religious influence in electoral politics as conservative and left-wing parties as fundamentally secular. Against these claims, I argue that the relationship between religion and electoral politics is shaped by the redistributive beliefs and preferences of religious leaders, who can become valuable allies of left-wing parties. I evaluate this argument in Brazil following the appointment of Pope John Paul II, leveraging as-if random variation in municipalities' exposure to progressive Catholic bishops. I show that bishops who actively supported state-led redistribution were essential to the electoral success of the left-wing Workers' Party (Partido dos Trabalhadores [PT]). Voters in municipalities with longer exposure to these bishops supported the PT at higher rates. The findings highlight the under-examined role of religious leaders in shaping the electoral influence of religion and provide evidence that these leaders can, in fact, be key for the development of left-wing parties, especially in the developing world.

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Political Analysis

A Multilevel Model for Coalition Governments: Uncovering Party-Level Dependencies Within and Between Governments

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Abstract. Abstract Coalition research increasingly emphasizes party-level explanations of coalition outcomes. However, this work does not account for the complex multilevel structure between parties and governments: many parties participate in multiple governments and governments often comprise multiple parties. In this paper, I show that this crisscrossing structure creates dependencies among observations both across and within governments. If ignored, these dependencies produce downward-biased uncertainty estimates that cluster-robust standard errors fail to fully correct. To address this issue, I then introduce a model that extends the Multiple Membership Multilevel Model to represent the multilevel structure of coalition government data. The model accounts for party-level dependencies across governments through party-specific effects in each coalition they join, and for dependencies within governments by representing the total party effect on a government as a weighted sum of its members' contributions. By allowing party weights to vary with covariates describing their interrelationships, the model enables researchers to examine the interdependent nature of coalition outcomes. I validate the model through simulation and an empirical application to coalition government survival, showing that ignoring party-level dependencies can produce misleading conclusions at all levels of analysis. The model is estimated via Bayesian MCMC and implemented in the accompanying R package 'bml'.

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A Dynamic Discrete Choice Approach to Attitude Stability and Constraint

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Abstract. Abstract We model attitude stability and constraint, using a dynamic discrete choice framework for multiple attitudes, to identify influential attitudes within attitude systems. Its value-added includes insights about different sources of (in)stability, the direction of causation between attitudes, and their relative degree of influence; capturing time-invariant individual traits with a multiple factor structure; and addressing the ordinal nature of attitudinal measures, together with heterogeneity in time intervals between interviews, across waves, and people. We examine five core political attitudes concerning how people view the political world and their role in it. Most of their variance reflects infrequently-changing individual characteristics and time-specific effects. Permanent heterogeneity plays a modest role. External efficacy is most influential concerning evaluations of the external political world, while internal efficacy is influential for views on one's role in politics. Another application examines the role of ideological and party identification on attitudes toward government spending and immigration. The attitudes form a weakly constrained attitude system. Party identification is the most influential, through spillovers to ideological identification. Party and ideological identifications are stable, time-invariant traits explaining most of their variance, with transitory shocks that hint at measurement error and/or expressive responding. Issue attitudes are unstable, driven mainly by transitory shocks.

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Accounting for Protest Voting in the U.S. Congress

2026-02-25 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10037

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Abstract. Abstract Members of the majority party in Congress sometimes vote against bills that they prefer over the status quo. We estimate a model of congressional roll-call voting that allows for this kind of non-ideological protest voting. We find that protest voting has significant implications for roll-call-based estimates of ideology and other analyses that rely upon them. For example, a traditional item response theory model curiously identifies members of the Squad as relatively moderate Democrats, but our protest-voting-adjusted scores identify them as the most liberal members of Congress. We also find that previous studies may have underestimated responsiveness, the effects of ideology in elections, the utility of non-roll-call-based measures of ideology, and the increase in congressional polarization. Although the implications for most substantive applications are likely modest, our analyses suggest that future researchers can better measure legislative ideology by accounting for a small number of non-ideological votes.

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Refining Gamson: The Isometric Log-Ratio Transformation and Portfolio Proportionality in Multiparty Governments

2026-02-25 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10036

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Abstract. Abstract One of the most robust empirical findings in political science is that in multiparty democracies cabinet ministries are distributed in rough proportion to parties' legislative seat shares, a pattern known as Gamson's Law. Yet existing research often overlooks the fact that portfolio and seat shares are compositional-mutually dependent parts of a whole. Standard methods treat them as unconstrained, risking bias, misleading uncertainty estimates, and flawed inference. Unfortunately, the most common strategy for handling compositions-the additive log-ratio (ALR) transformation combined with seemingly unrelated regression (SUR)-fails when the number and identity of compositional elements (like parties) vary across cases. We propose the isometric log-ratio (ILR) transformation-new to political science-as an alternative that both respects compositional geometry and adapts to differing compositional structures. Monte Carlo simulations show that ILR sharply outperforms standard approaches, reducing bias, improving coverage probability, and increasing statistical power. While we apply it to portfolio allocation, ILR provides a general solution for modeling compositional outcomes with other potential uses, including in electoral competition, where ALR+SUR has required strong assumptions or ad hoc adjustments. Using this improved methodology, we find that seat-portfolio proportionality is weaker overall than conventionally reported and varies substantially across governments.

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Science Advances

Public goods games on any population structure

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Abstract. Understanding the emergence of cooperation in social networks has advanced through pairwise interactions, but the corresponding theory for group-based public goods games (PGGs) remains less explored. Here, we provide theoretical conditions under which cooperation thrives in PGGs on arbitrary population structures, which are accurate under weak selection. We find that a class of networks that would otherwise fail to produce cooperation, such as star graphs, are particularly conducive to cooperation in PGGs. More generally, PGGs can support cooperation on almost all networks, which is robust across all kinds of model details. This fundamental advantage of PGGs derives from self-reciprocity realized by group separations and from clustering through second-order interactions. We also apply PGGs to empirical networks, which shows that PGGs could be a promising interaction mode for the emergence of cooperation in real-world systems.

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Trapped in declining occupations: Barriers to worker mobility in a changing economy

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Abstract. The US has undergone substantial changes in jobs, occupations, and mobility over the past two decades. Using administrative data from the US Occupational Outlook Handbook (2000 to 2020), we examine how immediate and projected occupational restructuring affects workers' mobility. In an update to prior research, we find that workers in both growing and declining occupations experience greater mobility than those in stable occupations. However, the direction of movement varies. Workers in declining occupations often move laterally into other declining occupations, with nearly 60% experiencing downward mobility. In contrast, growing occupations offer better prospects for upward mobility, particularly for workers transitioning from declining to growing occupations, where almost 50% enter higher-paying occupations. However, these moves to emerging jobs are relatively rare, accounting for only 5% of all occupational movements. These results highlight how recent shifts in the occupational structure exacerbate existing disadvantages for workers facing declining job opportunities.

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Communication Research

Radical Right-Wing Political Deepfakes Can Successfully Delegitimize Targeted Political Actors: Evidence From Three-wave Experiments in the US and The Netherlands

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Abstract. Political deepfakes potentially undermine democracy by amplifying socio-political divides in hyper-realistic manners. As an important next step in understanding the political consequences of deepfakes, this article reports on the longer-term effects of deepfakes across two different political settings: The US and the Netherlands. We conducted three-wave pre-registered experiments spanning a full week in which we exposed participants in the US and the Netherlands to realistic political deepfakes. We found that, in both political settings, exposure to deepfakes lowered support for the targeted political actor. This effect was strongest for people initially supporting the attacked politician. Although deepfakes had a delegitimizing impact, they were rated as substantially less credible than authentic videos. Although fact-checks were able to lower the credibility of deepfakes, the delegitimizing impact of deepfakes was resilient to corrections. These findings highlight the continued influence of corrected deepfakes on political beliefs.

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